

Russian Media in the Digital Age: Propaganda Rewired

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Abstract

This article reflects on the role of media in the Russian Federation through the concept of “rewired propaganda.” The approach highlights how the Russian regime copes with challenges to its information hegemony in the digital age. The study employs two critical case studies to examine the Russian political communication sphere: the 2011–12 election protests and the downing of Malaysia Airlines Flight 17 by a Russian missile in 2014. The article argues that a key vector of analysis is understanding strategic narrative as the critical measurement of media control. The findings suggests that it is not so much who owns or controls the media that is key to understanding information control; rather, it is knowing who is constructing and disseminating the most compelling national narrative that holds the key to power in Russia. This focus on rewired propaganda and recasting of the debate will permit an analysis of the role of the media in the post-Soviet state even as the overall media environment has shifted with the advent of the digital age. On balance, the two case studies demonstrate that Russian elites have continued to adapt to growing challenges, showing an ability to use many facets of communication to consolidate an information dominance over citizens.

Keywords

Russian media – propaganda – strategic narrative – state narrative – Russian internet – 2011–12 Russian election protests – Malaysia Airlines Flight 17 – Vremya – Sevodnya

The examination of the Russian media has long been hostage to the larger questions of the study of Russia in general. There is a tension between understanding Russia in context of the Soviet past, conceptualizing Russia as a

country striving toward democracy, and eventually attempting to comprehend how Russia has failed as a democratic state. When trying to analyze the role of the media, there is a fundamental distinction to be made. Are we attempting to understand how the media function in general in supporting or subverting democracy? Or are we analyzing the particular experience of the evolution of the media from a Soviet to a post-Soviet state? This article will examine two media crises and their coverage in Russia to analyze the state of the Russian media system: the 2011–12 election protests and the downing of Malaysia Airlines Flight 17 by a Russian missile in 2014. What emerges is the Russian state's continuing focus on media control and narrative: It is not so much about who owns or controls the media, it is more about who is constructing and disseminating the most compelling national narrative that holds the key to power in Russia. This recasting of the debate will permit an analysis of the role of the media in the post-Soviet state even as the overall media environment has shifted with the advent of the digital age. At the same time, it allows analysts to use the Russian case to advance the understanding of the role that media, including but by no means exclusively the online sphere, play in politics in transitional states in general.

What emerges from the study of the contemporary Russian media is a case study in how states that seek to control the news must confront both the challenge and the opportunity of the online sphere for an effective repressive regime. I argue that the challenge for contemporary autocracies lies in control, while the opportunities lie in the promise of enhanced propaganda – what this article will term 'rewired propaganda.' On the one hand, information control that draws its form and strength from the Soviet system with almost complete power over the mass media is no longer feasible in the contemporary media ecology. However, a commitment to disinformation and manipulation, when coupled with the affordances of the new digital age, give particular advantages to a repressive regime that can pro-actively shape the media narrative.

This article will weigh how Russia has fared in terms of both these challenges and these opportunities. On balance, the two case studies employed in this article demonstrate that Russian elites have continued to adapt to growing challenges, demonstrating an ability to use many facets of communication to consolidate its information dominance over its citizens.¹

1 This leaves aside the question of how well Russia is able to influence international news narratives.

Defining Rewired Propaganda

Moving beyond the vague and unhelpful label of ‘online revolution’, this article discusses the idea of ‘rewired propaganda.’ This concept follows the intellectual trajectory that increasingly has rejected a traditional/online media dichotomy and moves to a more dynamic conception of how information communication technology changes the media ecology in non-free states. The rewired propaganda theory posits that the key issues faced by authoritarian regimes from the internet is the way in which the online sphere challenges how the Russian state has traditionally dominated the information heights via television. Yet leaping to the conclusion that the internet can effectively undermine the state narrative and create an alternative, authoritative national news source has not proven useful in the Russian case. In addition, this idea is essentially too crude to illuminate the situation in other countries. This article posits that an examination of strategic state narratives in the digital age can serve as a useful analytical vector in understanding evolving media ecology and political dissent in non-free states.

While the factor of online information flows is important and different from the Cold War days, the new media ecology driven by the online sphere must be considered within a range of other factors. The idea of rewired propaganda builds particularly on work of Miskimmon, O’Loughlin, and Roselle in their analysis of strategic narrative as a measurable and critical variable in international relations.² In addition, the rewired propaganda theory relies on the utility of media ecology as discussed by scholars such as Hoskins and O’Loughlin and Chadwick.³ Chadwick argues in *The Hybrid Media System* that one cannot rely on either the logic of online news or the dominance of the traditional media systems; rather the two work in tandem.⁴ The notion of rewired propaganda also addresses the idea of liberation technology, the concept that the communicative affordances of the online sphere inevitably challenge authoritarian regimes.⁵ While there has been compelling evidence to show the dangers of online engagement in non-free states – specifically that it reveals

2 Alister Miskimmon, Ben O’Loughlin, and Laura Roselle, *Strategic Narratives: Communication Power and the New World Order* (New York and Milton Park: Routledge, 2013).

3 Andrew Hoskins, and Ben O’Loughlin, *War and Media* (London: Polity, 2010); Chadwick, Andrew, *The Hybrid Media System: Politics and Power* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2013).

4 Ibid.

5 Larry Diamond, “Liberation Technology,” *Journal of Democracy* 21, no. 3 (2010): 69–83.

dissenters to the government and puts them at grave risk⁶ – the internet can still be a game-changer in terms of the power balance between repressive state and subject/citizen.⁷ However, defining, measuring, and analyzing just what that shift may be is a significant challenge that is not really helped by sweeping statements about Facebook or Twitter ‘revolutions’.

The idea of rewired propaganda also relies heavily on the concept of state strategic narratives, which set out “the story of why a state is involved in a conflict, who is with the state and against the state, and how the conflict will be resolved”.⁸ But what is a ‘story’ for a state? This refers back to the theories of instrumentalism in national identity, particular as expressed by Benedict Anderson and the idea of “imagined communities”.⁹ This is the compelling idea that while citizens of states cannot personally know one another, they can share ideals and opinions via the mass media. While Anderson was discussing this concept in the context of the rise of profitable print media in vernacular languages, it is a powerful theory for conceptualizing the symbiotic relationship between media and national identity. While significant debate continues about the importance of primordial foundations of nation-states vis-à-vis instrumentalist nationalism such as that in an “imagined” community, there is strong evidence of how media systems reproduce and reinforce cultural norms. Indeed, it is impossible to conceive of any significant nation-state that does not have a national identity consistently expressed via mass media outlets.

What forms a state narrative? While Anderson highlights how the state narrative reflects and hence constructs a state identity, this is a broad theory. This article uses narratives on state-run television news as reasonable proxies to signal authoritarian state strategic narrative within the context of propaganda (i.e. propaganda in the internet age). While this issue is more complex in democratic societies, all authoritarian regimes practice tight control of the mass media. The form and nature of this control can vary from overt, pre-broadcast censorship to self-censorship inculcated by sanctions against journalists who

6 Evgeny Morozov, *The Net Delusion: How Not to Liberate the World*. (London: Allen Lane/Penguin, 2011).

7 Philip N. Howard, *The Digital Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy: Information Technology and Political Islam* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2011).

8 Laura Roselle, “Strategic Narratives of War: Fear of Entrapment and Abandonment During Protracted Conflict.” Paper presented at the American Political Science Association Meeting, Washington, D.C., 2010, p. 1, citing Andreas Antoniadis, Alister Miskimmon, and Ben O’Loughlin, *Great Power Politics and Strategic Narratives, CGPE Working Paper* (Brighton: Centre for Global Political Economy, University of Sussex, 2010).

9 Benedict R. Anderson, *Imagined communities: reflections on the origin and spread of nationalism*, Revised edition. (London: Verso, 1991).

overstep understood norms. While agenda setting and framing form the basis of much of political communication research, the study of narratives gives an opportunity to make a closer link between media content and state intentions by measuring strategic narratives.

The Russian Media Sphere

There are three key points necessary to understand about the Russian media: There is a large amount of media diversity except on key political topics; the vast majority of the media do not challenge the state on these key political topics; and Russian audience members are enthusiastic consumers of media content. Thus, there is an appearance of media diversity, but little meaningful challenge to the regime. While a vibrant oppositional media exists to a limited extent in traditional media and to a much larger extent online, the most influential and watched news outlet in the country is the heavily propagandized state-run First Channel.¹⁰ Russians report high engagement with media, especially with television: According to a 2013 survey of 5,012 Russians carried out by Gallup, 85 percent of Russians view television daily, 46 percent use the internet, and 28 percent listen to the radio. Seventy percent report that they have access to the internet at home. Older people are far more likely to report daily television use (92 percent of those over 55 compared with 73 percent of those 15–24 years old) and very few older people are online daily (12 percent of those 55 and older compared with 82 percent of those 15–24).¹¹

The Russian state controls, either directly or indirectly, all five of the major national television networks, as well as national radio networks, key national newspapers, and national news agencies (Freedom House, 2015).¹² The state also controls more than 60 percent of the country's estimated 45,000 regional and local newspapers and periodicals (Freedom House, 2015).¹³ In addition to broad state ownership of media, there are several other factors that limit media freedom in Russia. The most important issues are difficulty in funding for

10 Sarah Oates and Tetyana Lokot, "Twilight of the Gods?: How the Internet Challenged Russian Television News Frames in the Winter Protests of 2011–12." Paper presented at the International Association for Media and Communication Research Annual Conference, Dublin, Ireland, 2013.

11 See <https://www.bbg.gov/2014/01/08/bbg-research-series-contemporary-media-use-in-russia/> for a full report on the survey.

12 *Freedom House. Russia. Freedom of the Press.* (New York: Freedom House, 2016). Available online at <https://freedomhouse.org/report/freedom-press/2016/russia>.

13 *Ibid.*

commercial news ventures independent from government control; a lack of journalistic training and professionalism¹⁴; and a history of violence against journalists.¹⁵

After relatively slow adoption in the 1990s, Russians have embraced the internet with enthusiasm, growth fueled both by falling cost of access on mobile phones as well as a rich range of Russian online platforms. Russia enjoyed the fastest internet growth of any major European country from 2003 to 2013.¹⁶ As internet use grew, so did the scope of the engagement, with a number of societal protests being linked to online websites or campaigns. Russia developed its own version of Facebook (both VKontakte or InContact and Odnoklassniki or Classmates) as well as a lively blogging platform called LiveJournal (ZhivoiZhurnal) that attracted a huge following and a native search engine (www.yandex.ru) that outperformed Google in the country. According to the 2013 Gallup survey, the most popular online activity in Russia is using social networks (50 percent), followed by finding information (46 percent), Email (38 percent), getting news (37 percent), and watching videos (31 percent).¹⁷ At the same time, legacy media outlets such as the First Channel have been slow to develop an online presence, allowing native Russian news websites such as lenta.ru to dominate online news.¹⁸

Russia has not developed a tight set of controls on internet content and access. Rather, Russian officials have opted for more 'soft' controls on the internet through a series of laws (such as on laws on 'extremism') that give authorities wide power to censor and arrest individuals who challenge local or national bureaucrats.¹⁹ By making an example through intimidation and even

14 Svetlana Pasti, "Two Generations of Contemporary Russian Journalists", *European Journal of Communication* 20, no. 1 (2005): 89–115; Katrin Voltmer, "Constructing Political Reality in Russia: Izvestiya – Between Old and New Journalistic Practices," *European Journal of Communication* 15, no. 4 (2000): 469–500.

15 The Committee to Protect Journalists estimates that at least 56 journalists were killed for their work between 1992 and the end of 2013, see <https://www.cpj.org/killed/europe/russia/>.

16 Sarah Oates, *Revolution Stalled: The Politics Limits of the Internet in the Post-Soviet Sphere* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2013).

17 See <https://www.bbg.gov/2014/01/08/bbg-research-series-contemporary-media-use-in-russia/>. It is difficult with this type of survey to separate some of these categories – for example, people could be watching news videos, which would fit into two categories and possibly also relate to "finding information." However, this gives a useful overview of on-line activity choices for Russians.

18 Until the editor was removed and replaced in 2014, see <http://blogs.wsj.com/emerging-europe/2014/03/12/russian-news-editor-fired-after-interviewing-ukrainian-nationalist/>.

19 Oates, *Revolution Stalled*.

imprisonment of bloggers or even those who repost comments, the government can effectively create a climate of internal censorship that significantly limits the spread of political dissent online.²⁰

Citizen attitudes toward the media reflect skepticism about the idea of objectivity or balance.²¹ Rather, the media are more pragmatically viewed as mouthpieces for political factions. However, citizens report that they are willing to scan different outlets for news and employ an active engagement with the media in order to glean political information.²² Alternative news sites that challenge the Kremlin's framing of news exist, including the weekly newspaper *Novaya Gazeta* (*New Newspaper*) and a Latvia-based Russian language online news outlet called Medusa, run by the former editor of lenta.ru.

Thus, the situation in Russia is different either from a modern authoritarian state or from its own Soviet past. During most of the Soviet era (1917–1991), media were strictly controlled and independent media of any form were not tolerated. Although state controls waxed and waned (being most draconian under Stalin), the Soviet system defined the media as an ‘organ’ of the state, with the purpose of inculcating people with the values of Soviet communism. This was a completely different conception of the role of the media in Western democracies as a watchdog or even a player in fostering public consciousness.²³ However, the Soviet experience also included the era of glasnost (or media ‘transparency’) in the late 1980s in which the Soviet leadership decided to liberalize the media in an attempt to launch healthy self-criticism of the Communist Party. This led to a vibrant era of journalism, in which journalists used media outlets to examine society and promote alternate views so vigorously that the public became both enraged and engaged. Media coverage, particularly the public defiance of Soviet authorities by Russian television during a reactionary coup in 1991, played a key role in the collapse of the Soviet system in the same year.

While the media sector continued to be relatively diverse and free from state control in the early 1990s, heavy-handed Kremlin influence on the main state television news has spread into virtually every sector of the state and commercial media. Indicators of media freedom (such as those produced annually

20 See Freedom House *Freedom on the Net* reports at <https://freedomhouse.org/report/freedom-net/freedom-net-2015>.

21 Sarah Oates, *Television, Elections and Democracy in Russia* (London: Routledge, 2006).

22 Ibid.

23 Fred S. Siebert, Theodore Peterson, and Wilbur Schramm, *Four Theories of the Press: The Authoritarian, Libertarian, Social Responsibility, and Soviet Communist Concepts of What the Press Should Be and Do* (Champaign, IL: University of Illinois Press, 1956).

by the US-based Freedom House) show a steady decline of media freedom as measured by political, legal, and economic factors. In addition, media performance in elections has become progressively less free and fair.²⁴

The legacy of glasnost remains somewhat of a conundrum for Russians and Russian analysts alike. On the one hand, the Soviet glasnost era demonstrated the power of the media. On the other hand, glasnost did not leave affection or support for free media in Russia; rather, many of the media outlets were broadcasting views of different political factions in society rather than encouraging liberal democracy. Nor did the collapse of the Soviet system engender any particular love for the destabilizing power of the media on the part of citizens as the breakdown left a broad swathe of Soviet citizens stripped of their savings, jobs, pensions, benefits, and sense of pride in their country. The end of the Soviet era unleashed massive state corruption, in which a small number of people seized state assets to amass huge wealth and most of the rest of the population saw a decline in living standards.

Throughout these vast changes in society, state-run television has continued to dominate the media sphere in Russia. In particular, the First Channel (Channel One)²⁵ continues to be the most influential source of news in the country and serves as a key propaganda tool of the government.²⁶ In addition, the Russian government owns RT, an international, multilingual satellite news network, which has been relatively successful at promoting the Kremlin's framing of Russian and international news.²⁷

The First Channel has 51 percent of its shares in the hands of the state and 49 percent in the hands of enterprises. However, due to the fusion of state and commercial interests in the corrupt Russian state,²⁸ the Kremlin has control of Channel 1 news content, including the main nightly news program, *Vremya (Time)*.²⁹

24 Ibid. See analysis by the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe, <http://www.osce.org/odihr/elections/russia>. For an archived collection of media performance in Russian elections from the European Institute for the Media, see <http://www.media-politics.com/eimreports.htm>.

25 The name has been changed a few times since the Soviet era.

26 Oates and Lokot, "Twilight of the Gods".

27 Robert Orttung, "Russia's Propaganda Abroad: Strategy, Extent, and Effectiveness." Paper presented at the Annual Convention of the Association for Slavic, East European, and Eurasian Studies, Philadelphia, PA, 2015.

28 See Transparency International's report on corruption in Russia, <http://cpi.transparency.org/cpi2013/results/>. Russia is ranked as a very corrupt country by this international organization.

29 Oates and Lokot "Twilight of the Gods", for a more in-depth discussion of controls on Russian state television see Oates, *Television, Elections and Democracy*.

Vremya has been significantly modernized since Soviet times in look and feel. The content, however, continues a Soviet tradition of being sycophantic toward those in power: President Vladimir Putin, his United Russia party, and the state bureaucracy. This is obvious in quantitative and qualitative ways: Putin and his administration receive an asymmetrically large amount of time on *Vremya* broadcasts and the leaders are framed in the most flattering light possible with little real discussion of policy or opposition.³⁰ Some subjects, such as corruption by state officials and criticism of the ongoing conflict in Ukraine or Chechnya, are not aired. The United States is framed as the most powerful enemy to the country. The news program also actively participates in state *kompromat* (the Russian abbreviation for “compromising materials”) in a heady mix of misleading allegations, dubious film clips, and negative framing to attack regime enemies ranging from former U.S. ambassador Michael McFaul to the Communist Party of the Russian Federation to online dissident and political activist Alexei Navalny.³¹

It is not possible to say that the framing of events on *Vremya* follows an *exact* script from the Kremlin, although there is compelling evidence of heavy-handed news direction from the presidential administration. This is not limited to explicit directives given in regular meetings between news producers and the Kremlin. It is woven into the entire journalistic profession, in which the understood norm is that journalists work in the service of political or commercial factions.³² While there is variation even in the traditional news environment, mostly notably with outlets such as the liberal *Novaya Gazeta* (New Newspaper), state-run television is much more tightly controlled. Since the winter protests of 2011–12 over rigged elections, control of the traditional mass media has increased.³³ The Russian military incursion into Ukraine that started in 2014 has strengthened the nationalistic tone of the news. It is not always possible to ascertain the exact direction of state policy or wishes via the *Vremya* broadcasts. However, in the case of critical matters of state importance – who has been anointed as the next head of the United Russia party, plans for escalation in military conflicts, important switches in state

30 Ibid.

31 Much of this is documented in the analysis of election news coverage by the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe, see <http://www.osce.org/odihr/elections/russia>. For an archived collection of media performance in Russian elections from the European Institute for the Media, see <http://www.media-politics.com/eimreports.htm>.

32 For evidence of this pattern over time see Oates, *Revolution Stalled* and Oates, *Television, Elections and Democracy*.

33 *Freedom House*.

policy, who will win the next elections – coverage on *Vremya* is unambiguous and directive.

Media Control in Russia: Two Case Studies

Given the environment of the current Russian media system, how effective is the Russian state at controlling the media narrative? As discussed above, a useful way to measure this control is through an examination of state narratives and their power during times of political challenge. This article will now analyze two case studies in the Russian state's ability to control the narrative: media framing of the 2011–12 election protests in Russia and the shooting down of Malaysia Flight 17 by a Russian missile in 2014.

The 2011–2012 Protests

The 2011–12 protests were a watershed moment in post-Soviet Russian politics, representing the first significant street demonstrations since 1993. The protests were triggered by overt manipulation of December 2011 elections for the Duma, the lower house of the Russian Parliament. This followed some political unrest about Putin's decision to launch a third run for the presidency in the months preceding the election. Although Putin has been a popular president in Russia, his decision to run again made it clear that the Russian elites were closing ranks around him, obviating the need for voters to choose. In addition – particularly due to reports and videos purporting voter manipulation and falsification that were spread online – many Russians were forced to confront the widescale electoral fraud.

Earlier work identified several specific factors that were significant catalysts for these protests, most of which relate specifically to the rise of internet use in Russia: (1) over-reliance by the state on the power of self-censorship and fear among the population; (2) an online sphere that was freer than the traditional mass media in Russia; (3) a relatively recent explosion in internet use in Russia that eroded the dominance of state television in particular; (4) lack of understanding about citizen attitudes and the online sphere on the part of Russian elites; (5) the rise of crowd-sourcing; (6) the consolidation of online political networks; and (7) the role of online social entrepreneurs.³⁴ In the pre-internet age, the Russian state could either censor or bully media outlets into not challenging the state on key issues such as corruption among elites, the war in Chechnya, and skewed elections. The internet, however, made it

34 Oates, *Revolution Stalled*.

possible not only to tell people about conflicting information (such as obviously manipulated ballot results) but to show them the data itself (such as on the results page of the Central Election Commission website, in which many results had curious anomalies in favor of the ruling party – such as the 99.48 percent vote for the Kremlin's United Russia party in Chechnya).³⁵ It is this element of eyewitness evidence (particularly through uploaded videos) that particularly challenged the Russian state's control on information.

Unsurprisingly, reports on the size and scope of the protests differed on state television and on sources that were not close to the Kremlin, although all news sources agreed that the Moscow protests grew in size over the winter months.³⁶ The opposition reported 60,000 people at the first December protest, 120,000 at a second December protest, and 160,000 at the final large protest in February 2012.³⁷ In contrast, government sources claimed attendance ranged from 25,000 at the first protest to 36,000 at the final one. By the same token, the government claimed inflated figures for pro-Putin rallies that were organized by the state.³⁸

Just as the numbers differed, so did the overall framing of the protests on state-run television and on news sources that were not directed by the Kremlin. A qualitative analysis of coverage of the three large protest days during this Russian 'winter of discontent' shows that there were significant differences in coverage among state-run television news, commercial television news, and three important online news sources.³⁹ All three of these key information sources presented different aspects of the protests, although state-run news clung as much as possible to the frame of the protestors as either trivial, relatively small in number, and – most significantly – concerned with the proper implementation of government rules rather than disgusted with the government itself. Both commercial news and the internet framed the protests as

35 This data can be downloaded directly from the Russian CEC website at: (http://www.vybory.izbirkom.ru/region/region/izbirkom?action=show&root=1&tvd=100100028713304&vrn=100100028713299®ion=0&global=1&sub_region=0&prver=0&pronetvd=null&vi bid=100100028713304&type=233).

36 Regina Smyth and Sarah Oates, "Minding the Gap: Lessons on the Relationship among the Internet, Information, and Regime Challenge from Russian Protests", *Europe-Asia Studies* 67, no. 2 (2015): 285–305.

37 Sarah Oates, "Russian State Narrative in the Digital Age: Rewired Propaganda in Russian Television News Framing of Malaysia Airlines Flight 17." Paper presented at the American Political Science Association Annual Meeting Political Communication Pre-Conference at George Washington University, Washington, D.C., 2014.

38 Ibid.

39 Oates and Lokot, "Twilight of the Gods."

something quite different and with much more potential for political impact. In particular, commercial news made an attempt to show the true scope, scale, and character of the events (although as complaints from within the prominent NTV commercial channel suggest, this did come without a struggle in the controlled traditional media sphere in Russia).⁴⁰ The flagship commercial news *Sevodnya (Today)* on NTV nipped at the heels of the state-run *Vremya (Time)* on Channel 1 as it questioned state television's low estimate of crowds, framing the pro-Putin marches as engineered, and – most importantly – presenting the 'For Honest Elections' movement as a legitimate political force.

An important part of the story of the 2011–12 Russian protests is how the internet was able to contribute to much fuller coverage of the events. The internet was able to deliver much more detail due to both to its structure as well as a lower level of state oversight. There was a huge amount of space across the three most popular news websites to carry a lot of copy that would not fit into the minutes of a national newscast or even the inches of a print newspaper. Thus, there was space to show not only the words of the protestors and their leaders, but also to carry a wide range of citizen journalism as well as key logistical information about the events. This content then had the potential to be discussed, redistributed, repackaged, and commented upon by millions of Russians online, which is particularly important in terms of inculcating social capital beyond the edges of the protest crowds in Moscow and a handful of other Russian cities. Another key point is the relative lack of censorship in the online sphere. Although major websites are subject to scrutiny, pressure, and even the occasional shutdown in Russia, this was still relatively rare in 2011 and Runet maintained enough flexibility to make it extremely difficult for the Russian authorities to establish effective 'choke points' under the current system.

Ultimately, the key point is that while state-run news, commercial news, and the online news sphere are three different realms, the coverage of the Russian winter of discontent shows how there was 'bottom up' influence from the internet onto television. While state-run and even commercial television was constrained by the relatively strong controls on the Russian traditional media, the Russian internet was not subject to these controls in 2011 and 2012. Thus, there was a type of a 'trickle-up' media freedom in 2011 and 2012. As the internet reported on the true scale and meaning of the protests for Russians, this liberated commercial television to report in a more realistic and positive manner on the protests in terms of citizen mobilization. As commercial news

40 NTV journalist and *Sevodnya* host Alexey Pivovarov said he would not read the news if he could not report on the protests, see <http://www.reuters.com/article/russia-protests-media-idUSL6E7NB0GQ20111214>.

shifted the frame, the state-run news was forced to adjust its frame so as to come close enough to reality to be feasible to the viewer. Thus, the pressure on reporting truthfully and accurately welled up from internet to the state-run news even in a controlled media system. This meant that the Russian state was given a strong example of the dangers of a laissez-faire or piecemeal approach to control of the internet: It would either need to accept the greater engagement of the Russian public in politics or start controlling the internet more effectively to maintain its *de facto* control of the information space.

A key point relating to the media sphere in Russia is whether the 2011–12 protests marked a shift in the audience's attention from traditional media to online information. Evidence for this shift is not conclusive. By the first demonstrations in late 2011, the online sphere in Russia was prepared to play two key roles: mobilizing and informing citizens. Studies such as those by Samuel Greene show that information communication technology was important in organizing the protests, although people at the protests often cited influence from their friends rather than the internet itself as the motivating force to demonstrate in public.⁴¹ At the same time, surveys comparing the information sources and motivations of citizens at both anti-Putin protests and pro-Putin rallies found that there was not a complete split of the media spheres.⁴² While anti-Putin protestors were more likely to consume news and discuss politics online, pro-Putin demonstrators also were going online. Everyone was still consuming traditional media, although anti-Putin protestors were less attentive to it and more likely to seek out diverse information sources online. Thus, there was no complete division of the public between anti-Putin/online and pro-Putin/traditional media; media consumption was far more mixed and the internet did not emerge as a new, authoritative information space. This underlines the point that the internet is not a sphere separate from the political and media logics of the state – while it can affect both of these, it is still subject to laws and logics of political communication within a particular country.

Case No. 2: The Downing of Malaysia Airlines Flight 17

In the aftermath of the 2011–12 protests, the Russian government took measures to increase control of the online sphere.⁴³ However, there was no fundamental change in the approach nor uptick in violence against journalists; rather, the heightened control took the form of targeting social-media users deemed to

41 Samuel A. Greene, *Twitter and the Russian Street: Memes, Networks & Mobilization* (Moscow: The Center for New Media and Society, May 2012).

42 Smyth and Oates, "Minding the Gaps."

43 *Freedom House*.

post anti-government messages and additional laws. The next 'weapon' in limiting media freedom and creating propaganda stems from Russia's invasion of Ukraine. After the Euromaidan protests in Ukraine and Russia-backed Ukrainian President Viktor Yanukovych fled the country, Russian military took control of the Ukrainian territory of Crimea on the Black Sea in March 2014. Russia subsequently annexed Crimea into Russia through a referendum process that was criticized as a sham by Ukrainian and international observers.⁴⁴ In August 2014, Russian forces arrived in Eastern Ukraine to participate in fighting by pro-Russia militia groups in the Donbass region. The fighting continues to this day and Eastern Ukraine is now an occupied territory and an active war zone.

The invasion of Ukrainian territory launched an aggressive era of nationalism and propaganda in the Russian media, in which the incursions were framed as missions of liberation for oppressed ethnic Russians forced to live in 'occupied' territories. The sham referendum in Crimea was reported as a significant sign of the will of the people of the territory to join the Russian Federation. Dubious stories of Ukrainian 'atrocities' were circulated in the Russian media, including faked stories on state-run television that Ukrainians had crucified a Russian child.⁴⁵ There is evidence that this style of nationalism increased Putin's popularity, even as economic problems from plummeting oil prices continued.

This article uses state strategic narrative on *Vremya*, as measured by the news framing of the Malaysia Airlines Flight 17 attack, to showcase the nationalistic news style of the Russian media. Flight MH17 was an international flight from Amsterdam to Kuala Lumpur that was shot down over Eastern Ukraine on July 17, 2014, by a Russian missile, killing all 298 people on board. International consensus agrees that the plane was shot down by Russian militants, although Russia has consistently dismissed this finding.⁴⁶ This article will look at Russian media control in this case study via strategic narrative: How effectively did Russia construct and adapt its strategic state narrative in attempts to shift blame away from Russian militants or even a Russian weapon.

This narrative was measured by structured qualitative analysis of the coverage of Ukraine and MH17 as archived on the First Channel website in 106 news transcripts for news between 9 pm and 10 pm from July 17 through

44 For example, see the statement by the EU High Representative Catherine Ashton on March 1, 2014, available at http://eeas.europa.eu/statements/docs/2014/140301_01_en.pdf.

45 <http://www.stopfake.org/en/the-crucifixion-of-a-3-year-old-the-u-s-helped-kiev-shoot-down-flight-17-and-other-foes-the-kremlin-media-tell/>.

46 For example, see <https://www.theguardian.com/world/2015/oct/13/mh17-crash-report-plane-partially-reconstructed-blames-buk-missile-strike>.

July 23, 2014.⁴⁷ The news items were coded by the author to identify the main topic, location in broadcast, whether they presented more as news or propaganda, whether there was information that easily be identified as false/deviant from Western news coverage, as well as assignment of blame. More detailed studies of Russian propaganda have included innovative citizen-led projects such as Stopfake (stopfake.org) in Ukraine and work by Russian activist Maxim Katz on coding Russian television propaganda.⁴⁸

Unsurprisingly, the news about MH17 moved very quickly, particularly in the first 24 hours. *Vremya* did incorporate the alternate narrative very quickly as well, i.e. that the West and Ukraine almost immediately ascribed blame to the pro-Russia militia. By association, the blame then rested with Russia for arming the militia (a point that the Russians have always denied, but not very plausibly). The Russian television news continued to provide what Herman and Chomsky would call 'flak' to the Western frame, broadcasting a barrage of counter-claims while trying to discredit the evidence of the pro-Russia militia's military capability on the ground in Ukraine (as well as a recorded conversation in which Russian militants admit they shot down the plane by mistake).⁴⁹ These counter-claims and discrediting efforts morphed over the week to adapt to new evidence presented by others. Thus, there is a critical distinction between Soviet propaganda, which was able to control information flow to the point that challenging information was not broadcast, to the post-Soviet environment in which information flows are far more porous. In part, this is due to some freedom of the traditional mass media in contemporary Russia (such liberal newspapers and radio stations) but the real challenge comes from on-line information.

In what ways does the new media ecology *challenge* strategic narratives and in what ways can it actually *support* strategic narratives? While *Vremya* can ignore domestic actors who question the state online, it is more difficult to completely ignore powerful world actors such as the United Nations who are questioning Russian actions. For example, *Vremya* still felt compelled to carry the words of the U.S. President (including Obama's statement that the plane was shot down because Russia armed militias in Ukraine). If you cannot ignore the events, how do you try to shape them to fit a strategic narrative? This takes a multi-pronged approach on the part of state broadcaster, which is outlined

47 Oates, "Russian State Narrative in the Digital Age".

48 See <https://www.facebook.com/net.propagande>, https://vk.com/net_propagande and https://twitter.com/net_propagande.

49 Edward S. Herman and Noam Chomsky, *Manufacturing Consent: The Political Economy of the Mass Media* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1988).

here. If the state broadcaster is able to turn the conversation to resonate with Russian nationalism and national interests, that will then resonate among domestic internet users. In other words, this is the opposite attempt from what happened during the winter protests of 2011–12, in which there was a ‘trickle-up’ effect from internet reporting that forced a change in the narrative on state television. Here, Russian state television is weaving a complex counter-narrative to world opinion, with a range of factors discussed below, in order to maintain control of the message, if not all (online) media in the country.

Vremya consistently used episodic, rather than thematic, coverage of both the conflict in Ukraine and the MH17 tragedy itself.⁵⁰ While episodic coverage of disasters and conflicts is quite standard,⁵¹ it is interesting to note that episodic coverage of tragedy works well within the concept of rewired propaganda. If you ignore the inconvenient facts – playing on the emotions of your viewers through harrowing images, touching stories of lost family members, tales of bombings in small villages – episodic presentation of disasters is very useful in terms of connecting with the viewers. It stirs the emotions, giving the newscaster the ability to then direct the emotions with pro-Russia frames. Thus, if one can ignore the larger point that there would be no bombings in Eastern Ukraine if Russia had not armed the militia there, then it is relatively easy to ignite feelings of anger and disgust toward the Ukrainian army. By extending this emotional connection, it becomes possible to fit into a broader frame of American imperialism by reporting that ‘experts’ (including some quite dubious Americans) will point to how the United States is controlling the Ukrainian government. In the swirl of emotions and graphic images – from burnt plane wreckage to weeping survivors at funerals – emotion becomes the raw material with which the television news can shape citizen attitudes.

That being said, the shaping of the frame is visibly challenged by the new media ecology. While viewers are emotional, they are not indefinitely irrational. Why would people who have lived peacefully in Ukraine since the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 suddenly turn on each other? Why would almost all the other nations in the world claim Russia is responsible for arming the militia? How do you account for the conversation between two militia members discussing that a plane. they shot down?

Vremya dealt with all of this by a constant barrage of ‘flak’, finding points of refutation at each level. Ironically, *Vremya* (like news organizations around

50 In political communication theory, episodic coverage isolates news as events while thematic coverage attempts to place the news within the broader social context.

51 Shanto Iyengar, *Is Anyone Responsible? How Television Frames Political Issues* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1991).

the world) both used social media as a source (such as the Twitter account of Malaysia Airlines or the Facebook profiles of the victims) and criticized others for using social media in their reporting. For example, the fact that the militia conversation about their 'mistake' was posted via a Ukrainian minister's Facebook page was used to discredit the information. Here, *Vremya* was able to play on the viewers' suspicions that evidence can easily be falsified, particularly online. *Vremya* uses national interest to discredit the information presented by the United States government that tracked the rocket's trajectory to militia-held territory, pointing out that the information is suspect given the source. Later in the week, the 'information war' continues, with *Vremya* presenting data from the Russian government that there appeared to be another plane (evidently a Ukrainian fighter jet) next to MH17 when it exploded.

Overall, *Vremya's* attempts to challenge the dominant, international news frame that Russia was responsible for the deaths of the 298 on board MH17 can be summarized as:

- a) Failure to acknowledge or even really discuss that the conflict in Ukraine was caused by Russian intervention, especially in the arming of the Russian militia with weapons that included an anti-aircraft system that could destroy an airliner flying at 33,000 feet;
- b) Evidence that the militia launched the fatal rocket is dismissed because it is on social networks and was probably faked, it comes from the Americans, or it comes from the Ukrainians, who are also covering up their own military incompetence;
- c) The Ukrainian military has a history of shooting down commercial airlines by mistake with military weapons. The shooting down of a Siberian Airlines plane (killing an estimated 88 aboard) in 2001, a mistake that was not immediately acknowledged by the Ukrainian military, is brought up daily over the week on *Vremya*;
- d) Conspiracy/alternative theories, including that the flight was somehow transporting ill people or even corpses. One of the most persistent ideas promoted by *Vremya* was that there were one or two Ukrainian military jets in the sky when MH17 was destroyed. Various evidence offered for this theory include sketchy eyewitness accounts, a suspicious lack of data from Ukrainian air control, and uninformed speculation about the actual damage to the plane.
- e) When details are not helping a frame, a meta-narrative that ignores petty details and goes for an odd legal argument can be deployed. Putin repeated the idea several times that the country in whose airspace the disaster occurred must take responsibility. It doesn't matter that Russia

sent the rocket launcher into Ukraine (which they continually denied over the week of coverage and attempted to produce evidence showing it belonged to the Ukrainian military).

- f) There is also propaganda aimed at the Ukrainian population, notably scare-mongering about the draft (*Vremya* inaccurately reported that men up to 65 could be drafted), how the cost of the war will cut social services and pay in Ukraine, and the terrifying bombardment killing and injuring citizens in Eastern Ukraine.

Overall, *Vremya* shows that Russia is sympathetic while not at fault. Rather, Russians are victims of a U.S.-backed plot to weaken Russia's economy. This is all part of the American quest to dominate the world, according to the Russian strategic state narrative. It is here that the narrative veers into a particularly strange space, in two segments reporting that there was evidence that the United States had faked at least part of the 9/11 attacks in order to perpetuate world domination by a new invasion of Iraq.

While Russian state television was challenged by other Russian media outlets (commercial media and the internet) during the 2011–12 protests, there was more international challenge to the *Vremya* framing of MH17. Most challenging was that other countries were reporting consistently and compellingly that the plane was shot down by a Russian missile. *Vremya* was struggling to maintain a frame in the face of international news flow and counter-frames from influential global media outlets such as the BBC (for a comparison of BBC coverage with *Vremya* coverage, see Oates 2014). Indeed, the frames were so divergent that there was little agreement on facts at all. This is a shift from the difference in frames for the 2011–12 demonstrations. In addition, the protests were a domestic story, while the airline story was an international event with high attention from a global audience. In the case of the 2011–12 protests, ignoring and manipulating facts was somewhat easier for state-run television, but worldwide attention and divergent narratives made this impossible in the case of MH17.

Indeed, it would have been hard to design a more difficult news event to 'spin' in a positive way for the Russian involvement in Ukraine. The event is international in nature, with deep involvement with at least four countries (Malaysia, the Netherlands with the bulk of the victims, Russia, Ukraine) and the world's attention already was attuned to the tragic fate of another Malaysia Airlines flight that had disappeared over the South China Sea in March 2014. The MH17 flight had a very high proportion of children. With little control of the crash site in the aftermath of the disaster, unfiltered and highly disturbing images flooded the internet. This video witnessing made 'plausible deniability' even more difficult for the Russian television news.

Conclusions: Strategic Narrative as a Measure of State Media Control

The case studies in this article suggest that the new media ecology, for the most part, constrains the Russian strategic narrative and forces the Russian state to rewire its propaganda. Many classic elements of Russian propaganda as noted over time are present, yet in the case of MH17 the narrative had to shift and change due to pressures of information from international sources. Thus, the idea of online Russian citizen-journalists and witnesses challenging the state narrative is not strictly true. While there was compelling evidence of the ability of internet content (and commercial media) to shift the narrative of state television in the 2011–12 protests, it would appear that the Russian state was creating misleading national and international propaganda relating to Ukraine and the shooting down of MH17 in 2014. *Vremya* did not cite, even to denigrate, citizen protest or concerns over the Russian involvement in the MH17 attack or even its involvement in Ukraine. Rather, the energy expended by the First Channel was primarily in weaving and dodging to maintain a plausible Russia-first narrative in the face of world condemnation. Information available in the online sphere, measured here as news coverage from a different perspective, does change the game. However, it doesn't make it a winner-take-all game; rather, the effect can be seen in a shakier, albeit still nationalist narrative.

It must be said that this shifting, sometimes illogical media narrative in the wake of the Russian invasion of Ukraine is not yet taking its toll on popular support for the Putin regime. Unsurprisingly in the face of external condemnation and threat in the form of sanctions, the Russian public has rallied around their president. According to a study by the Levada Center in Russia, support for Putin jumped to 90 percent by August 2014, up from a more typical level of 60 to 65 percent.⁵² Even the State Duma and the government, generally not universally popular with Russians, enjoyed a rise in popularity, according to the Levada Center. Some of the population is concerned that Russia will become isolated over the Ukrainian conflict or sanctions, but only 38 percent reported this concern with a far greater number (58 percent) saying they were not concerned.

This evidence could leave us with the conclusion that Russians support their government even though government actions are leading to a military conflict with Ukraine that could be costly in terms of sanctions and lives of

52 This information is from an interview on August 11, 2014, with Alexei Levinson, head of socio-cultural research at the Levada Center reported here: <http://www.kommersant.ru/doc/2542566>.

Russian soldiers. That conclusion, however, fails to take into account the pressures that the new media ecology bring to the Russian strategic narrative. As we can see from the analysis of the media in the 2011–12 protests and in the *Vremya* coverage of МН17, the Russian state must rewire its propaganda to deal with global information flows and domestic online content. This is a significantly more difficult task than traditional propaganda carried out within a single authoritarian state that can control information flows via censorship.

This article has shown ways in which the internet and the international media can challenge the ‘information heights’ of Russian state-run television news. However, this is only a piece of the puzzle of the role of information in regime change. This article has not examined other intriguing areas of domestic information production, exchange, and aggregation in the online sphere. Yet thinking about information heights and state narratives is a way to bring further depth and nuance to understanding media ecology and regime challenge in the digital age. We know that the idea of a Facebook revolution is too broad and naïve. Yet, we wake up and find that authoritarian regimes do lose control of the narrative and fall. In thinking about strategic narratives, we may well find a better way to identify, measure, and analyze how critical change happens in information regimes. If authoritarian states must create rewired propaganda, we can measure the shape and nature of those attempts by looking first at the strategic narrative.